

THE FIRST HOUSE
By Avni Doshi
HARPERCOLLINS/ FOURTH ESTATE; ₹**599; 224** pages

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Avni Doshi's sophomore novel *The First House* (her debut book *Burnt Sugar* was shortlisted for the 2020 Booker Prize and published in India as *Girl in White Cotton*) has the most riveting opening paragraph of the year. It grabs you by the scruff of the neck and refuses to let go. "When my husband tells me he doesn't love me anymore, I reach for my neck. My head is missing. My husband has cut it off surreptitiously. He speaks to me as if my head was intact, still attached to my body, as though there's no cause for alarm. But he's holding it there, my head in his hands." The protagonist, born to Indian immigrant parents in the US, struggles with writer's block as well as the dissolution of her marriage. The end of the marriage and its aftermath, as well as the reactions of her friends, acquaintances and immediate family (her parents, her sister Didi, her cousin Sama, and her two young daughters) comprise the bulk of this excellent novel.

> In the afterword, Doshi credits the ideas of **Carl Jung and there** are several Jungian passages throughout the novel

"Anytime you are excavating the interior landscape of a character, there is a sort of requirement to really slow down and think about how the character arrives at certain epiphanies or realisations," says the 44-year-old Doshi. "Whether those realisations lead to a behavioural change is, of course, a different matter. In *The First House*, the protagonist learns things about herself and this leads to some old patterns being broken. But certain new, unsettling patterns begin to emerge, too."

In her previous novel, Doshi had "excavated the interior landscape" of a fraught mother-daughter relationship with razor-sharp sentences. Depicting interiority is clearly one of her strongest suits as a novelist. With every flashback, we learned a little more about the relationship's unravelling and eventual free-fall, and with every chapter set in the present, we learned more about how this impacted the protagonist's present-day personality. A similar method is followed with *The First House*, too, with seemingly small events marking the "new, unsettling patterns" Doshi speaks of. The protagonist forgets to eat or bathe, the family refrigerator languishes in disrepair, and she becomes obsessed with a statue of the goddess Diana at a neighbour's house. The Diana statue is one of the many mythological-religious figures and works of art directly referenced in the book—Draupadi, Apollo, Chhinnamasta (whose severed-head figure recalls the imagery of the opening para) et al make extended, recurring appearances, the protagonist thinking long and hard about their symbolic overtones and how they pertain to her life.

"I am a failed art historian," quips Doshi, humorously referring to her art history M.A. and her time as a professional curator working for galleries in Delhi and Mumbai. "It was through art history that I learned how to write, and a lot of my training is looking at a work of art and describing that encounter between the viewer and the work. I think that an artwork isn't really complete until that encounter happens. In fact, one of the things I love about writing is that it is so often a kind of curatorial activity. The way you decide what to hang on walls